

A FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY GUIDE

The Christian Spiritual Reset

*A 3-Day Guided Retreat to Overcome Burnout,
Hear God Clearly, and Renew Your Faith*

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FAITHFUL PATH COMMUNITY

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SESSION THREE

Release What You Are Carrying

Day 2, morning

Before you begin

Good morning. If you slept well, thank God for it. If you did not, that is not a failure; Day 2 will still hold. Follow the food and medication plan you established in Chapter 11, and do not begin this emotionally demanding session hungry, dehydrated, medically unstable, or physically unwell. Give yourself a few minutes of quiet with your drink before you open the Bible. You are not late.

This session begins the deeper part of the retreat. It is still gentle, and it still moves at your pace. But it asks you to look at what you have been carrying, and some of that may be heavy. If the session brings up more than you can safely hold, stop. That may mean pausing the exercise, ending the session, or ending the retreat and seeking appropriate support. Let safety, not completion, determine the next step.

Central passage

Matthew 11:28–30

Read the passage twice as written, the second time slowly, pausing after each phrase. Then pause and hear Christ's

invitation as addressed to you personally: "Come to me, [your name]..."

Teaching

Chapter 1 quoted this passage, and you may know it well. Familiarity is the danger. It is possible to have heard "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden" so many times that it no longer lands, so this session will try to hear it again, in the three movements the passage itself makes.

Come to me. Rest begins in relationship with Christ, not in a technique. Matthew does not limit "all who labor and are heavy laden" to one kind of burden. Yet elsewhere he records Jesus condemning religious leaders who "tie up heavy burdens, hard to bear, and lay them on people's shoulders" without lifting a finger to help (Matthew 23:4). It is therefore appropriate to include religious exhaustion among the burdens you may bring, while not reducing the invitation to that alone. Some of what you are carrying may have been laid on you in God's name. It is still a burden, and Jesus still says "Come."

Take my yoke. Notice that he does not say, "I will take your yoke away." A yoke was associated with labour and submission, and it became a natural image in Jewish teaching for accepting a teacher's authority and way of life. To take Jesus' yoke is to become his disciple: to place yourself under his teaching and learn his manner of obedience. Jesus does not merely offer a temporary break. He calls people to himself, places them under his teaching, and invites them to learn his way of life. The rest and the discipleship belong together.

So the difference lies not in the absence of a yoke but in the character of the teacher. The word translated "easy" carries the sense of something kind, good, or gracious rather than harsh.

Jesus' yoke is still a yoke; discipleship involves obedience. But its master is "gentle and lowly in heart," not cruel or oppressive. He does not drive his disciples through fear, humiliation, or endless attempts to prove their worth. If you have been driving yourself that way, you have been wearing someone else's yoke.

Learn from me. The rest he offers is not only relief; it is a different way of living, learned under a gentle Lord. You will not learn it in a morning. But you can begin.

This matters for the practical work of the session, because "release" can be misunderstood. Some people hear it as "drop everything," and then feel guilty because their children still need feeding and their work still needs doing. That is not what Jesus offers, and it is not what this session asks. In this session, release means four things: entrusting what you cannot control, sharing what should not be carried alone, taking faithful action on what genuinely belongs to you, and seeking counsel where responsibility is unclear.

On entrusting: release the attempt to control what lies outside your authority. You may still have a faithful response to make, but you are not responsible for producing another person's choice or guaranteeing an outcome. Some expectations placed on you are unhealthy, manipulative, or inconsistent with Scripture. Others may represent legitimate responsibilities you do not want to face. Do not make that distinction from feeling alone; test it through Scripture, wise counsel, and the actual commitments you have made.

On sharing: **1 Peter 5:7** says to cast "all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you." Peter does not promise that responsibilities disappear. He invites believers to place their anxieties into God's care while humbling themselves under his mighty hand (verse 6). You still take faithful action, but you do not

act as though your strength controls every outcome. And prayer may bring relief, but an anxiety disorder is not proof that someone has refused to cast their cares on God. Professional treatment, medication, practical support, and spiritual trust can belong together.

One caution before the exercise. Some burdens are the direct result of harm done to you, and "release" is not a way of pretending the harm did not happen or of relieving the person who caused it of responsibility. Entrusting the outcome to God does not mean withdrawing a report, abandoning a safety plan, cancelling a boundary, concealing wrongdoing, or relieving an offender of accountability. Release is not silence, reconciliation, or surrender to further harm. If what you carry includes abuse, injustice, or serious wrong done against you, this session is not asking you to let that go. Sessions Four and Six will give those things their own space.

Self-assessment

In your journal, make a list. Take ten minutes or more. Write down everything you are carrying right now: responsibilities, worries, fears, hopes you are holding for other people, expectations, guilt, unresolved situations. Do not sort them yet. Include the things that feel too small to mention. Include what you can name safely; if something feels too large, write only a general word such as "grief," "harm," or "something for professional support." You do not need to record details.

When the list is done, read it once, and then answer:

1. How long is the list? Did it surprise you?
2. Which item on it has been there longest?

3. Which item most affects your daily capacity? What kind of support, change, or faithful response might make it more manageable?

Guided prayer

*Jesus, you said to come to you, and I have come.
I am carrying more than I can hold, and I have been
carrying it as if no one else would.
Some of it is mine to act on.
Some of it I cannot control.
Some of it I should not carry alone.
I cannot always tell the difference.
Teach me.
Show me what to entrust, what to share, and what to
do.
I take your yoke, because you are gentle and lowly in
heart.
I cast on you the anxiety I have been holding, because
you said you care.
Give me rest, not from responsibility, but from carrying
it as though everything depends on me.
Amen.*

Silence

Suggested length: fifteen minutes, or the length you can manage.

Anchor phrase: **"Come to me, and I will give you rest."** Or, shorter: **"Gentle and lowly in heart."**

Sit with your list in front of you if that is helpful, or close the journal if it is not. Do not work on the list during the silence. Simply be in the presence of the one who said "Come," with everything you have written still in the room. Notice which item

your attention returns to, but do not assume repetition makes it the one you must address. You will choose where to begin based on safety, readiness, and wisdom.

When the timer ends, take one unhurried breath before moving. If you want to remain longer, you may; if you are ready to stop, stop.

Journaling

- 1. Go back through your list and mark each item with one or more of these letters. An item can carry more than one; "A/E" might mean take the action that belongs to me and entrust the result.

Mark	Meaning	Question to ask
A – Act	Something within my responsibility or control	What is the next faithful action?
S – Share	A burden needing practical, pastoral, relational, or professional support	Who should help carry this?
E – Entrust	An outcome or choice I cannot control	What am I trying to guarantee that belongs to God or to another person?
? – Seek counsel	Responsibility is unclear or potentially serious	Whose qualified wisdom do I need?

- 1. Look at the items marked E. What have you been trying to guarantee? Where did the sense that it was yours to guarantee come from?

2. Look at the items marked S. For each, name the kind of help it needs: a friend, a spouse, a pastor, a doctor, a counsellor, a colleague, a professional service.
3. Look at the items marked?. For each, name the right kind of guidance. A pastor or counsellor is not the correct authority for every burden; some need a doctor or mental-health professional, a domestic-abuse specialist, a safeguarding leader, a lawyer or financial adviser, an employer or HR representative, or a trusted family member.
4. Was anything on the list laid on you in God's name that Jesus might describe as a heavy burden, hard to bear? Write about it honestly. If you are not sure, say so.

Practical exercise: handing over

Take the index cards. Write one card per item, using the category it received. The wording below is a starting point; use your own words if they are truer.

Entrust cards: "I cannot control _____. I release my demand to guarantee the outcome. Show me any faithful action that still belongs to me."

Share cards: "I need help carrying _____. The person or service I will approach is _____."

Act cards: "The next faithful step within my responsibility is _____. I do not have to solve everything today."

Seek-counsel cards: "I will not make this decision alone. I will seek appropriate guidance from _____."

Read each card to God, aloud if you have privacy. Then place the Entrust cards face down somewhere set apart, under your Bible, in front of the cross if you brought one, or in an envelope marked with today's date. The location has no spiritual power. It is simply

a physical way of marking the decision you have made in prayer. You are not destroying these; you may want to look at them again on Day 3 or after the retreat.

Keep the Share, Act, and Seek-counsel cards together. They go back into your ordinary life with you, and Part Five will help you turn them into a plan.

If any card, at any point, brings up more than you can hold, stop, set it aside, and use the pause guidance from Chapter 5. That card can wait for Session Four, Session Six, or a conversation with the right person after the retreat.

Closing declaration

Read only what you can say honestly. Adjust the words if you need to.

I have come to Christ, who gives rest.

I release my demand to control what is beyond me.

I will seek help with what should be shared.

I will take the next faithful step in what belongs to me.

Christ is gentle and humble in heart, and I am learning his way.

Notes

Space for anything else you want to record from this session.

Before Session Four: this is important. Session Four is about lament and grief, and it should not follow directly on this one. The retreat schedule separates the heavier sessions of Day 2 with substantial rest, and this is where that pacing matters. Do not move directly into Session Four. Take a substantial break, preferably an hour or more, and follow your planned food,

medication, rest, and movement needs. Begin the next session only when you feel sufficiently settled.